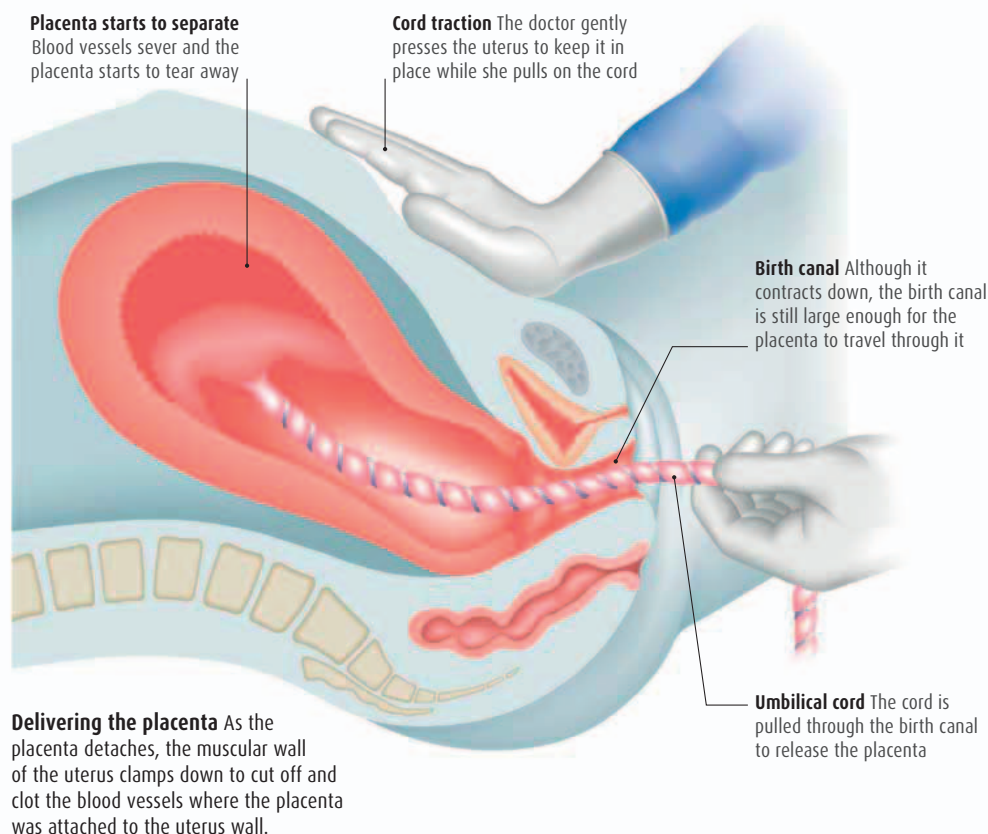


Q What is the “third stage” of labor and what will I need to do during this stage?

Your baby has arrived, but labor is not quite over. Once you’ve enjoyed a first embrace, there will be a few more contractions to deliver the placenta and membranes.

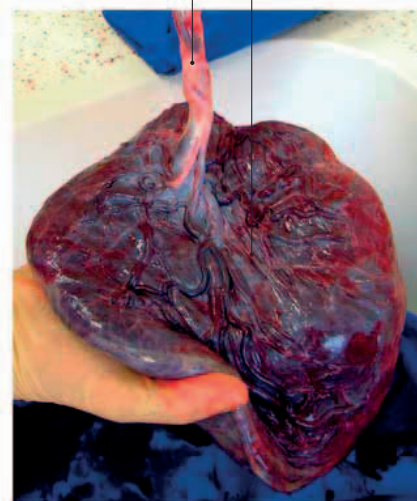
Although arguably the most exciting part of labor is over, there is still the business of giving birth to the placenta and membranes that have nourished and protected your baby during pregnancy. Your placenta, which begins to come away from your uterus lining as soon as your

baby’s body is out, bears down on your perineum, just as your baby had, triggering the release of more of the hormone oxytocin, which keeps your contractions coming. Your doctor will guide you through these contractions and in most cases only a few pushes are needed to get the placenta and membranes out. Compared to the delivery of your baby, you may not feel the delivery of your placenta very much or at all. There will be some bleeding as the placenta comes away from the wall of the uterus.



Umbilical cord If the umbilical cord isn’t cut, it will pulsate for up to ten minutes

Network of vessels In the placenta, blood vessels radiate from the umbilical cord



A healthy placenta The average full-term placenta weighs around 1 lb 2 oz (500 g) and is 8–10 in (20–25 cm) in diameter. The membranes also need to come out of the uterus to avoid the risk of infection and serious bleeding.

Q I just want to get to know my new baby. How long will the third stage take?

This depends on whether you opt to deliver the placenta naturally, or to have medical assistance to deliver it. Without medical intervention, third stage labor usually takes 20–30 minutes, but it can take up to an hour. With medical intervention, this stage may take only around 15 minutes or less. For many women who decide to deliver the placenta naturally, it’s just a matter of three pushes and

the placenta comes out. If the process takes longer than an hour, you are at an increased risk of excessive bleeding and your doctor will talk to you about active management to deliver your placenta (see below).

Q What is an “active” third stage of labor? Should I opt for it?

An active third stage is one that is managed medically by speeding up the delivery of the placenta. There is evidence that an active third

stage reduces the risk of serious bleeding after the birth, known as postpartum hemorrhage. An active delivery is uncommon in the US, and it’s unlikely that your doctor will offer you the procedure if you don’t mention it. If your doctor agrees to manage the delivery of your placenta actively, you’ll receive an injection of synthetic oxytocin hormone—which triggers contractions that help release the placenta—in your thigh around the time of your baby’s birth. Your doctor will pull gently on the umbilical cord, drawing the placenta away from the uterine lining and out of your vagina, with the attached membranes following behind.